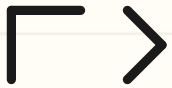
To the detectives:







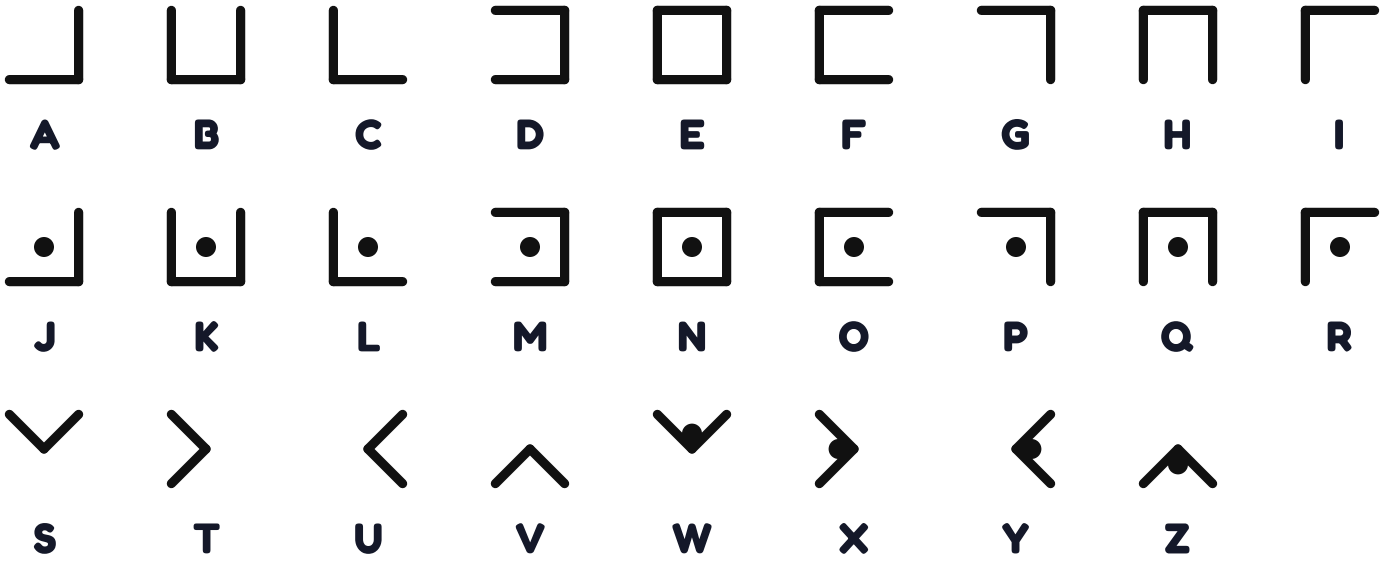
— ?

write the P.S. here in yellow highlighter, then it disappears

CIPHER ROOM

# Pigpen cipher key

Every letter lives in a cell of a tic-tac-toe grid or an X. The symbol for a letter is the **shape of its cell**. Letters J through R and W through Z add a dot. Match the shapes to the letters. Nobody has to memorize anything.




### How to decode as a squad

1. Five words, five detectives: everyone takes one word.
2. Find each shape on this key. Write the letter on the line under the shape. Watch for the dot: a dot means the second set of letters.
3. Read the words together out loud.
4. Then sweep the blacklight across the whole page. Thieves always leave something behind.

### Why the thief used it

Pigpen is a 400-year-old substitution cipher. It looks impossible and takes about three minutes once you know the trick. Our thief is a show-off. Show-offs make mistakes.

Print two: one taped to the Cipher Room table, one in the station lead's folder.

STATION LEAD ONLY

# Answers and how to make the notes

| The note decodes to |
| --- |
| **YOU WILL NEVER FIND IT** (5 words, 18 letters, one word per detective)  |

**The hidden P.S. on every note (this is Clue 3)**

*"P.S. Snagged my blue sweater on the shelf. Worth it."*

## Making the notes

1. Print page 1 four times on plain paper (cream or white), one note per squad. Every squad gets the same note.
2. Below the dashed line on each note, write the P.S. in **yellow highlighter** in your own messy handwriting. Fresh highlighter glows brightest. Test one under the blacklight before you do all four.
3. Crumple each note and flatten it once so it looks like it was slipped under a door.
4. Fold each one. The station lead hands a fresh one to each squad and keeps the used ones.
5. Hint budget at the station: two free hints per squad. Make them ask. If a squad is stuck, give them the first word.

Want the note to say something else? Keep it to five words and edit the `data-text` in `printables/halloween/ransom-notes.html`; the glyphs redraw themselves.